in mid-September recovered 15 kg gold from state officials and contractors being probed for alleged irregularities in the implementation of the Jal Jeevan Mission and in the department of information technology and communication. But in the absence of a clear command structure at the state level, the whole pyramidal network that could have amplified that charge of "corruption and inefficiency" has been left enfeebled and spiritless.

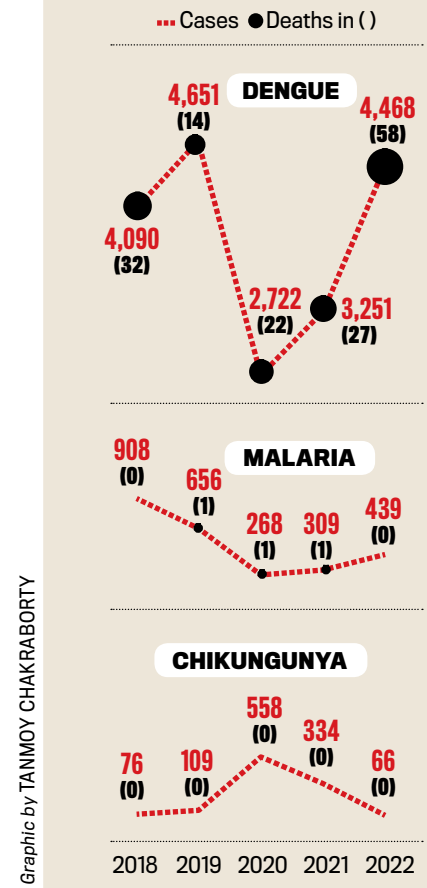
Unlike the Congress, where Gehlot is clearly leading the campaign, the BJP cadre is clueless about which leader to approach within the state. Modi remains the face of the party, though the fact that there was some rethinking about "overexposing" the PM after his Sikar rally reveals a touch of anxiety on that front. In the name of "collective leadership", however, the party's central command continues to call the shots, based on surveys and inputs from sources independent of the state unit.

With the latter's writ thus circumscribed, ticket-seekers are refraining from spending personal resources to mobilise support for rallies, as there's no guarantee their efforts will bear fruit. That's why only a few strong leaders managed to draw bigger crowds at the yatra rallies. Most logged an average turnout barely touching 1,000—a number that would queue up by the roadside or on rooftops just to see former CM Vasundhara Raje during her yatras in 2003 and 2013. Her small rallies, too, attracted crowds well above 10,000. (Led by Raje, the BJP unseated Gehlot both times.)

This time, the marked ambivalence towards her is posing the biggest challenge to the BJP down the line. Unlike in Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh, the party has not been able to release even its first list of candidates. A central election committee meeting on Rajasthan is still awaited. A state-specific committee—which, at one time, Raje was expected to head—is yet to be constituted. Still, the anti-Raje lobby here is trying to convince the high command that the party can sweep the elections without her. A stalwart from that camp reasons that her side is left with no presence in any state or district body. But despite a free hand, not a single leader has been able to match Raje's stature, even after her being sidelined.

THE BJP'S FAILURE TO NAME ITS CM FACE AHEAD OF THE ASSEMBLY POLLS IN RAJASTHAN HAS LED TO CONFUSION AMONG THE PARTY CADRE

That has sharpened the question on everyone's mind, from booth-level workers to senior functionaries: if not Raje, who? Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, perhaps? Or Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla? Or Leader of Opposition Rajendra Rathore? Or will the Modi-Shah combine pull a rabbit out of the hat—Rajasthan's version of an M.L. Khattar and Pushkar Singh Dhami? If so, even general secretary (organisation) Chandrashekhar, active in the state for seven years, and Rajasthan BJP president C.P. Joshi could fancy their chances. Still, a far cry from those rock-solid decades when a Bhairon Singh Shekhawat or a Raje imparted order. ■



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

By Jeemon Jacob

The fourth Nipah virus outbreak in Kerala in six years has tossed a few questions in the air. To be sure, the disease has claimed only two lives till now—the state's redoubtable public health apparatus, going into overdrive with its well-rehearsed control measures, has largely tamped down on its spread. But the very reappearance of Nipah, a fruit bat–borne virus with a very high mortality rate of 40-70 per cent, has spread a different kind of infection: fear. The question on everyone's mind is, what makes the state seemingly uniquely prone to vector-borne and zoonotic diseases? Ever since chikungunya claimed nearly 100 lives in 2006, Kerala has been stalked nearly incessantly by serial killers of the microbic ilk—being the first port of call in India for Covid was only a fitting side-story.

This episode began on September 13, after the test results of two men who had died over the past fortnight